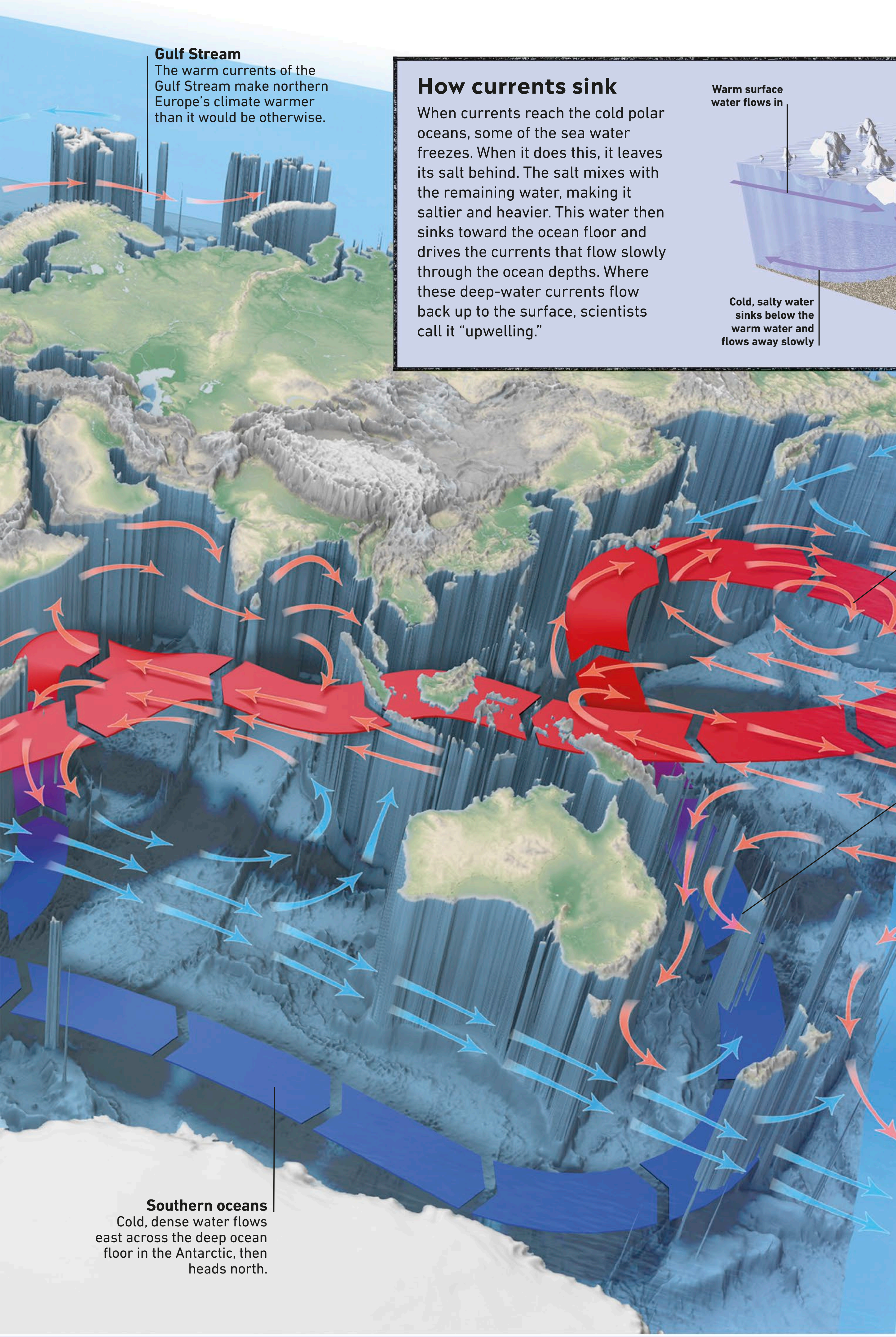
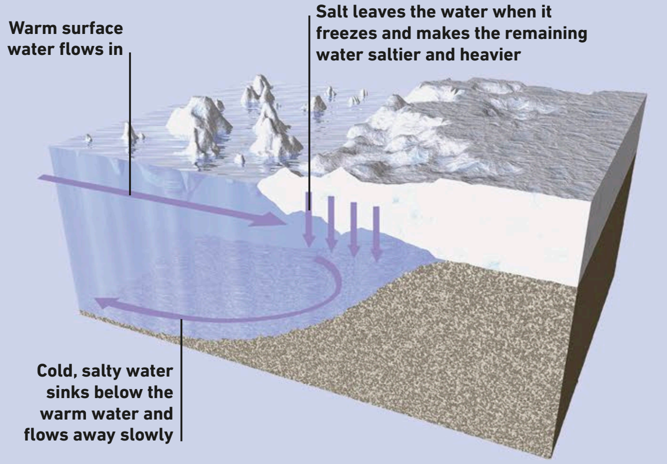


How currents sink

When currents reach the cold polar oceans, some of the sea water freezes. When it does this, it leaves its salt behind. The salt mixes with the remaining water, making it saltier and heavier. This water then sinks toward the ocean floor and drives the currents that flow slowly through the ocean depths. Where these deep-water currents flow back up to the surface, scientists call it "upwelling."



Friendly floaters

A cargo of plastic ducks lost in the Pacific in 1992 has helped scientists learn more about the speed and direction of ocean currents ever since. Some of the ducks drifted over 17,000 miles (27,500 km).